The Sugar Duties of 1787 and the Bristol Refiners

Introduction

The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. No account of the trade can ignore the part played by the factors, who stood between the planter and the merchant and took a commission from both.

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The structure of the duties

Letters took from five to eight weeks to cross the Atlantic, so that every decision was made on information that was already out of date. Some of the most revealing documents in the collection are the least formal: a note about a wet cargo, or a list of things to be bought for a ship. The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number. What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt. Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. A ship's master was at once a navigator, a trader and a disciplinarian, and the owners trusted him with a good deal more than the sailing of the vessel.

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- The Amity lay 16 days in the river waiting for a wind, and her master asks that his demurrage be allowed.

The rate in 1787

In 1787 the duty on muscovado sugar imported into Bristol stood at 15 shillings the hundredweight, and the Treasury did not raise it until the spring of 1789. The refiners, who had expected a reduction after the Treaty of Versailles, complained to the Customs that the rate fell most heavily upon the coarser sorts.

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The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart, partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court. No account of the trade can ignore the part played by the factors, who stood between the planter and the merchant and took a commission from both. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge.

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The effect on the Bristol trade

If the muscovado sugar is damp on arrival we shall claim upon the underwriters, and I beg you to have a surveyor's certificate ready. A letter from Mr. Withers at London says that candles will be taken only at a discount of three per cent, which I have declined. The price of salt beef in the Bristol market stood at £60 9s 7d the hundredweight when the Providence came up the Avon, and I doubt it will hold. The warehouse in Queen Square is full of mahogany, and until the Betsey is cleared I cannot receive any more. The clerk has copied the bill of lading twice, as Mrs. Dunning would not accept the first for the want of a seal. Freight to Montego Bay is now £8 0s the ton, and the underwriters at the Exchange ask seven per cent for the voyage.

I cannot tell you how the indigo will sell until the spring fleet is in, for the grocers of London are buying from hand to mouth. Your account of the rum is noted, but the sample you sent was middling, and I would not take more than 82 bundles on those terms. The price of mahogany in the Bristol market stood at £71 19s 7d the hundredweight when the Amity came up the Avon, and I doubt it will hold. The cooper reports that the casks of the last lot were green and weeping, and that 15 of them had to be re-hooped before the lighter would take them. The Betsey lay 11 days in the river waiting for a wind, and her master asks that his demurrage be allowed.

I have seen Mrs. Dunning at the Exchange, and payment for the salt beef is promised before Lady Day. Be so good as to send by the next conveyance a statement of what stands to our credit with Mrs. Dunning, for the half-yearly balance is close at hand. Freight to Waterford is now £7 5s the ton, and the underwriters at the Exchange ask six per cent for the voyage. The wharfinger asks £42 11s 11d for the landing of the pimento, which I think too much, and I have told him so.

The cooper reports that the casks of the last lot were green and weeping, and that 3 of them had to be re-hooped before the lighter would take them. The wharfinger asks £71 17s 11d for the landing of the iron bars, which I think too much, and I have told him so. The clerk has copied the bill of lading twice, as Mrs. Dunning would not accept the first for the want of a seal. Freight to Montego Bay is now £3 10s the ton, and the underwriters at the Exchange ask four per cent for the voyage. Your account of the molasses is noted, but the sample you sent was damp, and I would not take more than 46 barrels on those terms. The wharfinger asks £78 5s 10d for the landing of the indigo, which I think too much, and I have told him so.

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Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Madeira had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. The chapter that follows rests chiefly upon the letters of the years 1783 to 1790, which are the most complete in the collection.

Conclusion

No account of the trade can ignore the part played by the factors, who stood between the planter and the merchant and took a commission from both. Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them. The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike. No account of the trade can ignore the part played by the factors, who stood between the planter and the merchant and took a commission from both.

The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Falmouth had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number. No account of the trade can ignore the part played by the factors, who stood between the planter and the merchant and took a commission from both. Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them.

Notes

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The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike.

A letter from Messrs. Lyle & Pountney at London says that Madeira wine will be taken only at a discount of three per cent, which I have declined.